

PLANNER

BEFORE YOU GO IN

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Free to use. Please credit Noer (Misbah) Hameed.

Open with curiosity, not conclusions.

Start with "I wanted to talk about X because I want to understand what is going on" not "You have been doing X and it needs to stop."

Separate observation from interpretation.

"I noticed you have missed the last three deadlines" is an observation. "You do not care about this work" is an interpretation. Stay in observation.

Ask before you tell.

Before you share your view, hear theirs. You may learn something that changes everything.

Silence is not failure.

Pause after you ask something hard. Give them time to think. Do not fill the silence.

AFTER THE CONVERSATION

1. What did you agree on?

Tip: Write it down within the hour.

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2. What is each person doing next, and by when?

Tip: No clarity here means nothing changes.

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3. When will you follow up?

Tip: Set a date before you leave the room.

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A difficult conversation handled well builds more trust than a dozen easy ones. The goal is not to win. It is to be understood, and to understand.